DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Pregnancy and Birth: How Everything Comes to Be

Daat Tevunot §138-141

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §138-141
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 22 June 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Clearing up Tuesday's confusion

The class started by reviewing Tuesday's material, which had left some of the group unsure. Sections 7 to 9 discuss how Hashem relates to the world, and there are two overarching modes:

- **The mode of justice (hanhagat hamishpat):** Hashem responds to our deeds with consequences, good and bad. This is the evident mode, the one throughout the Torah.
- **The mode of Yihud, or sovereignty:** Hashem overrides the system and steers the world to its end. It works in the background, and "it doesn't care if you do good or bad". It is set aside for now.

Within the mode of justice there are two parts: (a) how Hashem directs the emanations that come from Him, and (b) how He guides the way we receive them. In brackets, the Ramhal adds that within (a) there is always "sweetness within the darkness". Even harsh emanations are softened, because they come from love. That is why it is "two which are three". Footnote 12 in the English edition sets out the three categories.

A participant asked about Rosh Hashanah, when we ask Hashem to rise from the throne of justice to the throne of mercy. The Rabbi explained that this is not a request within the first mode. It is a request to move from the overarching mode one towards mode two, or at the least to suspend the consequences.

The Ramhal quotes the Rambam

Before explaining the two parts, the Ramhal gives an introduction built on a metaphor of pregnancy and birth, and he quotes the Rambam. The Rabbi pointed out how unusual this is. Apart from Tanakh and Hazal, the only Rishon the Ramhal ever quotes is the Rambam.

The Rabbi offered his own explanation. The Ramhal died young yet wrote a great many works and poems, and his best known books (Mesillat Yesharim, Derech Hashem, Daat Tevunot) are classics. "The answer is he found one path and he took that." He focused on Tanakh, Hazal and the Rambam and did not spend time on anyone else. "Most of us can't do that," said the Rabbi. We are not certain enough to follow only one teacher, so we have to learn from everyone.

A participant raised the tradition that the Ramhal was taught by a maggid, an angel. The Rabbi said he could not comment and preferred "to give people their credit that they worked hard". Much of Daat Tevunot is original philosophy, especially the treatment of evil in Sections 4 to 6, although it is grounded in Hazal and the Zohar. Derech Hashem in particular is a systematic presentation of what is found in Hazal and the Zohar.

The meaning of "birth" in Tanakh

The Rambam explains that the verb yalad, to give birth, is used in Tanakh in two borrowed senses:

1. **Things coming into existence.** "Before the mountains were born", as we say on Shabbat morning, means before they came into existence.
2. **Thoughts coming to fruition.** "He conceived iniquity and gave birth to falsehood": an idea is "born" when it comes out.

The Rabbi summed up both as "potential being actualised".

The Ramhal's three principles

The Ramhal takes this further, in three steps.

First: before birth comes pregnancy. If coming into existence is called birth, then the stage when something is in the pipeline is called pregnancy. Nothing successful happens "from one day to the next". Like a child carried for nine months, every idea and project must first be carried and developed, and if the pregnancy is not looked after, what is born may be flawed.

Second: existence and perfection are two separate things. Everything has its basic existence and, beyond that, its perfection, and each needs its own emanation. Hidden in every pregnancy is the potential not only to bring something into being but also to complete it. The Rabbi first compared this to the placenta. A participant offered a better analogy, which the Rabbi accepted: a mother who gives birth then has to raise the child. The potential for the child's perfection is already there. It still has to be brought out.

Third: everything is connected. The Ramhal comes back to the interconnected system, "like the cogs" in a machine. Everything depends on and gives birth to something else, and the whole universe is "one big existence" that is only complete with all its details. So whenever Hashem sends an emanation, there was a pregnancy before it, a cause, and the emanation itself carries further potential.

Why it matters

So when we look at any of Hashem's acts in the world, we should not look only at the visible result. We should also ask where it came from and what else it is "pregnant" with that may be born in the future. When that potential is fully brought out, its perfection will be clear to see. The Ramhal says that those who think this through will understand many secrets and find many questions answered.

The Rabbi said that the following week they would see how these principles are applied to the way Hashem deals with the emanations that come from Him.

Summary

- The mode of justice has two parts, how Hashem sends His emanations and how we receive them, and the first is always sweetened by love.
- The Ramhal quotes only the Rambam among the Rishonim, which the Rabbi sees as a sign of his single-minded focus.
- In Tanakh "birth" means potential being actualised, whether things coming into existence or ideas coming to fruition.
- Before every birth comes pregnancy. Existence and perfection are separate, and the potential for perfection is already within.
- Everything is connected, so every emanation has a cause before it and further potential after it.

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